

Solomon built a Temple that followed the pattern of the Tabernacle, so that God would have a place to dwell at the center of the land given to the Israelites.

The purpose of the Temple was to provide a way that God's people could approach God without dying in the process. When Moses was on Mount Sinai, he asked to see God's glory in its fullness. God told Moses that he would die if he were to see the fullness of God's glory, but he could see God's back (Exodus 33:17-23).

When the Angel of the Lord appeared to Gideon, he did not recognize who it was at first. Later when the Angel of the Lord performed a miracle, Gideon realized that by just seeing the Angel of the Lord, he would likely have to die. But the voice of God assured Gideon that he would not need to die (Judges 6:11-24).

When the Angel of the Lord appeared to Samson's parents, Manoah, the father, said, "We will surely die for we have seen God" (Judges 13:22).

My point is that by having a special place where God's people could offer sacrifices for their sins, God's people were able to live with God's presence in their midst. God did not have to strike them dead for their sinfulness because their sins were being forgiven because of their sacrifices offered in the Temple.

Holiness is a word used to describe God. God's holiness is a deadly threat to sinners. They cannot be in God's presence and live, because of their sin. As long as God's people were faithful to God, offering sacrifices to God, and obeying God in their daily lives, they would live at peace with God.

The problem had been that they didn't live up to the way of life God had commanded them to follow. They didn't even keep up with the sacrifices they were supposed to offer to God. So God sent them into exile.

The stories of Ezra and Nehemiah shows that God did not give up on creating a way for His people to live at peace with Him. We also see that even though building the Temple was the right thing to do, building the Temple was not enough. They had to live by God's Law.

When is a temple or a group of people holy?

God was present with Ezra and the people who worked so hard to follow every detail found in God's Law that would make worship in the Temple everything God wanted it to be. We read several times in the book of Ezra how God's hand was on Ezra and the people:

- [Ezra 7:6](#) "this Ezra went up from Babylonia. He was a scribe skilled in the Law of Moses that the Lord, the God of Israel, had given, and the king granted him all that he asked, for the hand of the Lord his God was on him."
- [Ezra 7:9](#) "For on the first day of the first month he began to go up from Babylonia, and on the first day of the fifth month he came to Jerusalem, for the good hand of his God was on him."
- [Ezra 7:28](#) "and who extended to me his steadfast love before the king and his counselors, and before all the king's mighty officers. I took courage, for the hand of the Lord my God was on me, and I gathered leading men from Israel to go up with me."
- [Ezra 8:18](#) "And by the good hand of our God on us, they brought us a man of discretion, of the sons of Mahli the son of Levi, son of Israel, namely Sherebiah with his sons and kinsmen, 18;"
- [Ezra 8:31](#) "Then we departed from the river Ahava on the twelfth day of the first month, to go to Jerusalem. The hand of our God was on us, and he delivered us from the hand of the enemy and from ambushes by the way."

God not only blessed this work, His hand was on it.

God worked miraculously so that King Artaxerxes gave them the same Temple furniture that King Cyrus had given to them. (We don't know what happened in the 57 years in between but King Artaxerxes mentions giving these items to them in the letter quoted in Ezra 7:12-26. After the letter is quoted Ezra writes,

Ezra 7:27-28 "Blessed be the Lord, the God of our fathers, who put such a thing as this into the heart of the king, to beautify the house of the Lord that is in Jerusalem, and who extended to me his steadfast love before the king and his counselors, and before all the king's mighty officers. I took courage, for the hand of the Lord my God was on me, and I gathered leading men from Israel to go up with me."

It is true that God's hand was on Ezra and the people. However, that did not mean that everything was good. In fact, when Ezra arrived in Jerusalem, he found that the people, including the priests, were guilty of worshipping false gods. They were worshipping false gods because the men were married to women who lived in the area who worshipped false gods, and the women were married to men from the area who worshipped false gods. The problem was not so much a matter of racial intermarriage as it was mixing worship of the true god with worship of false gods.

When Ezra realized how serious this sin was he was profoundly upset.

Ezra 9:1-3 "After these things had been done, the officials approached me and said, "The people of Israel and the priests and the Levites have not separated themselves from the peoples of the lands with their abominations, from the Canaanites, the Hittites, the Perizzites, the Jebusites, the Ammonites, the Moabites, the Egyptians, and the Amorites. For they have taken some of their daughters to be wives for themselves and for their sons, so that the holy race has mixed itself with the peoples of the lands. And in this faithlessness the hand of the officials and chief men has been foremost." As soon as I heard this, I tore my garment and my cloak and pulled hair from my head and beard and sat appalled."

Ezra realizes that this is a terrible problem:

Ezra 9:10, 14 "shall we break your commandments again and intermarry with the peoples who practice these abominations? Would you not be angry with us until you consumed us, so that there should be no remnant, nor any to escape?"

Ezra had traveled 900 miles to get to Jerusalem. The trip had taken 4 months through desert and very dangerous country. Had God brought them through all of this only to destroy the last hope that the Jewish people might have a future that fulfilled God's prophecies for His people?

A "national day of repentance" was declared. All the leaders came to the Temple in Jerusalem. They were outside in the rain:

Ezra 10:9-12 "Then all the men of Judah and Benjamin assembled at Jerusalem within the three days. It was the ninth month, on the twentieth day of the month. And all the people sat in the open square before the house of God, trembling because of this matter and because of the heavy rain. And Ezra the priest stood up and said to them, "You have broken faith and married foreign women, and so increased the guilt of Israel. Now then make confession to the Lord, the God of your fathers and do his will. Separate yourselves from the peoples of the land and from the foreign wives." Then all the assembly answered with a loud voice, "It is so; we must do as you have said."

Everyone pledged that they would separate themselves from their wives and children who were part of the lifestyle followed by the idol worshippers who lived in the area around them.

What a terrible thing to put away wives and children they had loved. It is difficult to imagine God requiring such a high price from His people, but He did.

God's hand was on Ezra. God's hand was on the people. As difficult as it is for us to understand, this was necessary if God's people were to have a future. They would have continued to be absorbed into the idol worship of other nations. They would not have been a people set apart for God. By giving up their idol worship they could be God's people. God forgave them because they had repented of their sin.

In the very last verse of the book of Ezra we read:

Ezra 10:44 "All these had married foreign women, and some of the women had even borne children."

What hope is there that anyone will be holy?

Perhaps the first question in your mind is, "If I am married to a non-Christian woman do I need to divorce her? If I have children who don't believe in Jesus, do I need to tell them I can't live in the same house with them?"

We don't have to struggle to know how to answer these questions because the Apostle Paul answered these questions. The first Christians faced this type of situation repeatedly because most of them had not believed in Jesus when they got married. They came to Jesus after getting married. So many of the first Christians were married to spouses who did not believe in Jesus. What should they do?

Paul says,

1Cor 7:13-17 “If any woman has a husband who is an unbeliever, and he consents to live with her, she should not divorce him. For the unbelieving husband is made holy because of his wife, and the unbelieving wife is made holy because of her husband. Otherwise your children would be unclean, but as it is, they are holy. But if the unbelieving partner separates, let it be so. In such cases the brother or sister is not enslaved. God has called you to peace. For how do you know, wife, whether you will save your husband? Or how do you know, husband, whether you will save your wife? Only let each person lead the life that the Lord has assigned to him, and to which God has called him. This is my rule in all the churches.”

Paul asks the question, If a man or woman is married to an unbeliever, should the believer divorce the unbeliever? That is what happened in the story of Ezra. The believers made a pledge to divorce their unbelieving spouses.

Why does Paul answer the question so differently from Ezra? Paul makes it clear, if a believer stays with an unbelieving spouse there is always the possibility that their faith in Jesus may become an example to their spouse. When their spouse sees how Jesus fills a believer's life with a sense of purpose and joy, they may also become a believer. In other words, a believing spouse is the best chance a person has to be brought to faith in Jesus. Believers should not throw such an opportunity away.

On the other hand, Paul says, if the unbelieving spouse leaves, or in our day and age, files for divorce, then it's over. Don't fight it. Let them go. Why? Because they have made the decision that they don't want to live with someone who believes in Jesus.

Paul's understanding is that those who believe in Jesus should always be doing all they can to present the Gospel to others so that they can come to believe in Jesus Christ as Lord and Savior.

How come Ezra didn't try to do something like that? In Paul's letter to Titus, he explains:

Titus 2:14 [Jesus] “gave himself for us to redeem us from all lawlessness and to purify for himself a people for his own possession who are zealous for good works.”

When Jesus died on the cross, He redeemed every believer. His sacrifice purified believers. Every believer became His possession.

In Ezra's time the Jewish people belonged to God as His chosen people. Jesus' death on the cross “has broken down ... the dividing wall of hostility” between Jew and Gentile (Ephesians 2:14). Now people of every nation can come to believe. Jesus commanded His disciples to bring the Gospel to every nation on earth (Matthew 28:19-20). This possibility was not available in Ezra's time because Jesus had not yet come.

Does this mean that those who follow Jesus don't have to live holy lives because Jesus makes them holy? Paul tells believers to offer their “bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God, which is your spiritual worship” (Romans 12:1). Followers of Jesus must live holy lives. Only Jesus could pay the price for their sins, and make them holy. But because they have been made holy, they must live lives that demonstrate holiness in all they do.

There is a great deal more to say about the importance of believers to live holy lives. But one concern that most believers have is that if they sin, does this mean they can never again be holy.

Consider the story of Ezra once again. God had His hand on every part of the process of getting the Temple rebuilt, getting His chosen people settled in the land, and getting His chosen people on a path toward living holy lives. At nearly every turn God's people failed Him. But God never gave up. God knew then that He was going to send Jesus. If He had given up on the people who were living in Judah during Ezra's time Jesus would not have been born to people who were expecting a Messiah. No one would have known about the prophecies God had given. God didn't give up on His plan to send Jesus to be the Savior of the World.

Also notice one other very important part of the story. The people repented of their sin. Even true believers must repent of their sins. When we sin, we must ask God to forgive us.

If you sin, ask God to forgive you. Turn your life around and move in the direction of holy living which God has directed you to follow.

If you're concerned that you failed, recognize that God won't give up on you as long as you keep coming back to Him. That's what we see in Ezra's account, God does not give up on His plan for His people. He's not finished yet. If you are in Christ, He will make you holy. [Philippians 1:6](#) "And I am sure of this, that he who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ."

Ezra 7:1–8:28

K J K R B M S H O U S E
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Now after this, in the reign of **Artaxerxes king** of Persia, **Ezra** the son of Seraiah, son of Azariah, son of Hilkiah, son of Shallum, son of Zadok, son of Ahitub, son of Amariah, son of Azariah, son of Meraioth, son of Zerahiah, son of Uzzi, son of Bukki, son of Abishua, son of Phinehas, son of Eleazar, son of Aaron the chief **priest**— this **Ezra** went up from **Babylonia**. He was a scribe skilled in the Law of Moses that the **LORD**, the God of **Israel**, had given, and the **king** granted him all that he asked, for the **hand** of the **LORD** his God was on him. And **there** went up **also** to **Jerusalem**, in the seventh year of **Artaxerxes** the **king**, some of the **people** of **Israel**, and some of the **priests** and **Levites**, the singers and gatekeepers, and the temple **servants**. And **Ezra** came to **Jerusalem** in the fifth month, which was in the seventh year of the **king**. For on the first day of the first month he began to go up from **Babylonia**, and on the first day of the fifth month he came to **Jerusalem**, for the **good hand** of his God was on him. For **Ezra** had set his heart to study the Law of the **LORD**, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in **Israel**. This is a copy of the letter that **King Artaxerxes** gave to **Ezra** the **priest**, the scribe, a man learned in matters of the commandments of the **LORD** and his statutes for **Israel**: "**Artaxerxes, king of kings**, to **Ezra** the **priest**, the scribe of the Law of the God of **heaven**. Peace. And now I make a **decree** that anyone of the **people** of **Israel** or their **priests** or **Levites** in my kingdom, who freely **offers** to go to **Jerusalem**, may go with you. For you are sent by the **king** and his seven **counselors** to make inquiries about Judah and **Jerusalem** according to the Law of your God, which is in your **hand**, and **also** to carry the **silver** and **gold** that the **king** and his **counselors** have freely **offered** to the God of **Israel**, whose dwelling is in **Jerusalem**, with all the **silver** and **gold** that you shall find in the whole province of **Babylonia**, and with the freewill **offerings** of the **people** and the **priests**, vowed willingly for the **house** of their God that is in **Jerusalem**. With this money, then, you shall with all diligence buy bulls, rams, and lambs, with their grain **offerings** and their drink **offerings**, and you shall **offer** them on the altar of the **house** of your God that is in **Jerusalem**. Whatever seems **good** to you and your brothers to do with the rest of the **silver** and **gold**, you may do, according to the will of your God. The **vessels** that have been given you for the service of the **house** of your God, you shall deliver before the God of **Jerusalem**. And whatever else is **required** for the **house** of your God, which it falls to you to provide, you may provide it out of the **king's** treasury. "And I, **Artaxerxes** the **king**, make a **decree** to all the treasurers in the province Beyond the River: Whatever **Ezra** the **priest**, the scribe of the Law of the God of **heaven**, **requires** of you, let it be done with all diligence, up to 100 talents of **silver**, 100 cors of wheat, 100 baths of wine, 100 baths of oil, and salt without prescribing how

much. Whatever is **decreed** by the God of **heaven**, let it be done in full for the **house** of the God of **heaven**, lest his wrath be against the realm of the **king** and his sons. We **also** notify you that it shall not be lawful to impose tribute, custom, or toll on anyone of the **priests**, the **Levites**, the singers, the doorkeepers, the temple **servants**, or other **servants** of this **house** of God. "And you, **Ezra**, according to the wisdom of your God that is in your **hand**, appoint magistrates and **judges** who may **judge** all the **people** in the province Beyond the River, all such as know the laws of your God. And those who do not know them, you shall teach. Whoever will not obey the law of your God and the law of the **king**, let **judgment** be strictly executed on him, whether for death or for banishment or for confiscation of his **goods** or for imprisonment." Blessed be the **LORD**, the God of our fathers, who put such a thing as this into the heart of the **king**, to beautify the **house** of the **LORD** that is in **Jerusalem**, and who extended to me his steadfast love before the **king** and his **counselors**, and before all the **king's** mighty officers. I took courage, for the **hand** of the **LORD** my God was on me, and I gathered leading men from **Israel** to go up with me. These are the heads of their fathers' **houses**, and this is the genealogy of those who went up with me from **Babylonia**, in the reign of **Artaxerxes** the **king**: Of the sons of Phinehas, Gershom. Of the sons of Ithamar, Daniel. Of the sons of David, Hattush. Of the sons of Shecaniah, who was of the sons of Parosh, Zechariah, with whom were registered 150 men. Of the sons of Pahath-moab, Eliehoenai the son of Zerahiah, and with him 200 men. Of the sons of Zattu, Shecaniah the son of Jahaziel, and with him 300 men. Of the sons of Adin, Ebed the son of Jonathan, and with him 50 men. Of the sons of Elam, Jeshaiiah the son of Athaliah, and with him 70 men. Of the sons of Shephatiah, Zebadiah the son of Michael, and with him 80 men. Of the sons of Joab, Obadiah the son of Jehiel, and with him 218 men. Of the sons of Bani, Shelomith the son of Josiphiah, and with him 160 men. Of the sons of Bebai, Zechariah, the son of Bebai, and with him 28 men. Of the sons of Azgad, Johanan the son of Hakkatan, and with him 110 men. Of the sons of Adonikam, those who came later, their **names** being Eliphelet, Jeuel, and Shemaiah, and with them 60 men. Of the sons of Bigvai, Uthai and Zaccur, and with them 70 men. I gathered them to the river that runs to Ahava, and **there** we camped three days. As I reviewed the **people** and the **priests**, I found **there** none of the sons of Levi. Then I sent for Eliezer, Ariel, Shemaiah, Elnathan, Jarib, Elnathan, Nathan, Zechariah, and Meshullam, leading men, and for Joarib and Elnathan, who were men of insight, and sent them to Iddo, the leading man at the place Casiphia, telling them what to say to Iddo and his brothers and the temple **servants** at the place Casiphia, **namely**, to send us ministers for the **house** of our God. And by the **good hand** of our God on us, they brought us a man of discretion, of the sons of Mahli the son of Levi, son of **Israel**, **namely** Sherebiah with his sons and kinsmen, 18; **also** Hashabiah, and with him Jeshaiiah of the sons of Merari, with his kinsmen and their sons, 20; besides 220 of the temple **servants**, whom David and his officials had set apart to attend the **Levites**. These were all mentioned by **name**. Then I proclaimed a **fast there**, at the river Ahava, that we might humble ourselves before our God, to seek from him a safe journey for ourselves, our children, and all our **goods**. For I was ashamed to ask the **king** for a band of soldiers and horsemen to protect us against the enemy on our way, since we had told the **king**, "The **hand** of our God is for **good** on all who seek him, and the power of his wrath is against all who forsake him." So we **fasted** and implored our God for this, and he listened to our entreaty. Then I set apart twelve of the leading **priests**: Sherebiah, Hashabiah, and ten of their kinsmen with them. And I weighed out to them the **silver** and the **gold** and the **vessels**, the **offering** for the **house** of our God that the **king** and his **counselors** and his **lords** and all **Israel there** present had **offered**. I weighed out into their **hand** 650 talents of **silver**, and **silver vessels** worth 200 talents, and 100 talents of **gold**, 20 bowls of **gold** worth 1,000 darics, and two **vessels** of fine bright bronze as precious as **gold**. And I said to them, "You are holy to the **LORD**, and the **vessels** are holy, and the **silver** and the **gold** are a freewill **offering** to the **LORD**, the God of your fathers.

(ESV)